

INCLUDED WITH YOUR ARMORY SUBSCRIPTION

Weapons & Covert Ops Toolkit

Eight sections covering the weapons knowledge, tactical reality, and covert operations detail that separates authentic action thrillers from the ones that fall apart the moment a reader who knows better picks them up. Built from the perspective of Jonathan Baxter -- The Brit -- a man who has been in those rooms, used those weapons, and would prefer you got the details right.

Jeff Bonilla - The Writers Precinct - 2026

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SECTION 01

How The Armory Works -- Meeting The Brit

Jonathan Baxter -- The Brit -- is not a consultant. He is not a Wikipedia entry with better grammar. He is a man with a specific history, a specific set of skills, and a dry, precise way of explaining things that reflects the world he came from. Understanding who he is will help you understand how to use him.

WHO JONATHAN BAXTER IS

The Brit is a covert operations specialist -- the kind of professional whose official biography is deliberately incomplete. He has worked in environments where weapons are not accessories but tools, where tactical decisions happen in seconds, and where the difference between a correct detail and an incorrect one is not a matter of craft -- it is a matter of survival. He brings that precision to every answer.

"Most writers describe a weapon the way someone describes a car they've only seen in a film. The weight is wrong. The sound is wrong. The way a person holds it under stress is entirely wrong. These things matter -- not because readers are pedants, but because authenticity is felt before it is analyzed."

-- Jonathan Baxter (The Brit), The Armory

HOW TO USE THE ARMORY EFFECTIVELY

The Armory is built for specificity. The more specific your question, the more useful the answer. Vague questions get functional answers. Precise questions get the kind of detail that makes a scene feel lived-in.

Weak question: "What gun would my character use?"

Better question: "My protagonist is a former SAS operative working in an urban environment in 2019. What sidearm would he carry off-duty, and how would he carry it?"

Weak question: "How does a silencer work?"

Better question: "My character uses a suppressed weapon in a closed room. What would the sound level actually be, and what would a person in the next room hear?"

Weak question: "What would an explosion look like?"

Better question: "A vehicle IED detonates 40 meters from my protagonist. What does he experience physically in the first three seconds?"

SECTION 02

Firearms -- What Fiction Gets Wrong

Firearms are the most written-about weapons in thriller fiction and the most consistently misrepresented. The errors fall into predictable categories -- and trained readers, military veterans, law enforcement officers, and sport shooters notice every single one.

THE MOST COMMON FIREARM ERRORS IN FICTION

The Endless Magazine

The error: Characters fire far more rounds than their weapon holds without reloading. A standard Glock 17 magazine holds 17 rounds. A 1911 holds 7-8. A revolver holds 5-6. Counting rounds is not pedantry -- it is the source of some of the most genuine tension available to action writers. Running dry at the wrong moment is drama. Ignoring it is a missed opportunity and a credibility failure.

The fix: Know your weapon's capacity. Count the shots. Let the reload be a scene element.

The Safety That Isn't There

The error: Writers frequently have characters click off a safety on weapons that don't have external manual safeties. The Glock -- one of the most common handguns in fiction -- has no external manual safety. Neither does the SIG Sauer P320. Clicking off a safety that doesn't exist tells every gun owner in your readership that you've never held the weapon.

The fix: Research the specific make and model your character carries. Know its manual of arms.

The Hollywood Suppressor

The error: Suppressors (incorrectly called silencers) do not make weapons whisper-quiet. A suppressed 9mm still produces approximately 130 decibels -- louder than a jackhammer. What suppressors do is reduce the sound to a level that doesn't cause immediate hearing damage and makes the shot harder to locate. "A soft pfft" is fiction. A sharp, muffled crack is reality.

The fix: Describe the suppressed shot as loud but directionless. The character in the next room hears something -- they're just not sure what.

Instant Knockdown

The error: Handgun rounds do not reliably knock people down, throw them backward, or produce instant incapacitation unless the central nervous system is directly hit. People who are shot often continue functioning for seconds to minutes depending on the wound location. Adrenaline is a remarkable analgesic. A character shot in the shoulder does not spin dramatically and collapse.

The fix: Research terminal ballistics for your specific scenario. Wound location determines behavior. The most dangerous shot victim is one who doesn't yet know they're dying.

Racking the Slide for Drama

The error: Characters rack the slide of a pistol to signal readiness or intimidation -- but a pistol carried in condition one (round chambered, hammer cocked or striker ready) does not need to be racked. Racking an already-chambered round ejects a live cartridge onto the floor. A professional does not do this.

The fix: Your character either carries chambered (ready immediately) or unchambered (requires a rack to fire). Pick one and be consistent. The rack-for-drama is a tell.

SECTION 03

The Realities of Combat and Tactical Operations

Combat in fiction is almost always wrong in the same direction -- it is too clean, too controlled, and too cinematic. Real violence is chaotic, fast, and followed by consequences that fiction routinely skips.

THE TIMELINE OF A GUNFIGHT

Most real gunfights are over in under ten seconds. The average number of rounds fired is three to five. The average distance is seven meters or less. There is no cover dialogue, no dramatic monologue, no slow-motion assessment. There is noise, movement, and the specific terror of not knowing if you've been hit until it's over. Fiction that stretches a gunfight across pages must earn that expansion with interior experience, not extended choreography.

WHAT THE BODY DOES UNDER FIRE

Adrenaline produces specific, documented physiological effects: tunnel vision (peripheral vision narrows dramatically), auditory exclusion (gunshots sound distant or absent), time distortion (events feel slower or faster than they were), and fine motor skill degradation (precise movements become difficult). A trained operator manages these effects. An untrained person is overwhelmed by them. Your character's training level should be reflected in how their body responds.

COVER VERSUS CONCEALMENT

Cover stops bullets. Concealment hides you. A car door is concealment -- most pistol rounds pass through it. A car engine block is cover. A wooden interior wall is concealment. A concrete pillar is cover. Fiction routinely treats concealment as cover, which tells every veteran and shooter in your audience that your character should be dead.

THE AFTERMATH

Shooting someone -- even justifiably, even in self-defense -- produces documented psychological consequences. Shaking. Nausea. Hyperawareness. Intrusive replaying of the event. Professional operators are trained to manage these responses and still experience them. A character who shoots someone and immediately proceeds to the next plot point without any physiological response reads as either a sociopath or an author who has never thought about this.

"The most common mistake is writing a gunfight the way a person who has only watched gunfights would write it. The second most common mistake is writing the aftermath the way someone who has never had to live with one would write it. Both are detectable. Both are fixable."

-- Jonathan Baxter (The Brit), The Armory

SECTION 04

Weapons by Genre and Setting

The weapon a character carries is a character choice, not an arbitrary prop. It signals training, access, era, geography, and professional identity. Getting this right requires matching the weapon to the world.

CONTEMPORARY THRILLER / SPECIAL OPERATIONS

- > SIG Sauer P226/P320 -- standard NATO special forces sidearm, widely issued
- > Glock 17/19 -- ubiquitous, reliable, carried by operators and law enforcement globally
- > HK416 -- assault rifle of choice for tier-one units including DEVGRU and GIGN
- > MP5 -- still used for close-quarters and hostage rescue by specialist units
- > The Brit's personal preference: a suppressed SIG, carried condition one, no drama

COLD WAR / ESPIONAGE (1950s-1990s)

- > Walther PPK -- the iconic intelligence service sidearm, compact, reliable, now dated
- > Makarov PM -- standard Soviet/Eastern Bloc sidearm, every KGB field officer carried one
- > Browning Hi-Power -- widely issued to Western forces and intelligence services
- > AKM/AK-74 -- the opposition's rifle. Know which variant by decade and geography
- > Note: Cold War tradecraft preferred knives, poisons, and hands over firearms where possible

HISTORICAL / WWII

- > M1911A1 -- standard US officer sidearm, heavy, reliable, still respected
- > Luger P08 / Walther P38 -- German service pistols, distinctly different in character
- > Sten Gun -- British cheap-and-dirty submachine gun, known for accidental discharges
- > Thompson M1928 -- American, heavy, reliable, beloved and iconic
- > Note: WWII weapons are heavy, loud, and mechanically distinct from modern equivalents

CRIME / STREET-LEVEL THRILLER

- > Glock 19 -- the most common illegal firearm in urban US crime scenes
- > Revolver (.38 Special) -- still carried by older criminals who distrust semi-autos
- > .357 Magnum -- significant stopping power, significant noise, significant recoil
- > Sawn-off shotgun -- intimidation weapon, devastating at close range, impractical beyond 10 meters
- > Note: street-level weapons are often old, poorly maintained, and unreliable

SECTION 05

Covert Operations -- The Architecture of Secrecy

Spy fiction and covert operations thrillers suffer from a specific set of myths -- most of them generated by franchise films that prioritized spectacle over accuracy. The reality of intelligence and special operations work is simultaneously more mundane and more interesting than the fiction suggests.

INTELLIGENCE WORK IS MOSTLY WAITING

The popular image of the spy is action-driven. The reality is surveillance, documentation, relationship cultivation, and patience measured in months. The moment of action -- if it comes at all -- is the product of weeks of preparation and is usually over in minutes. Fiction that acknowledges this rhythm has a texture that franchise thrillers lack entirely.

COVER IDENTITIES ARE FRAGILE

A cover identity is a performance maintained under stress, often for extended periods, in environments where a single inconsistency can be fatal. The maintenance of cover -- remembering the legend, staying in character when exhausted or frightened -- is a specific skill that takes years to develop and can fail at any moment. This fragility is dramatically rich territory that most fiction underuses.

CHAIN OF COMMAND AND DENIABILITY

Covert operations exist specifically because governments need actions they can deny. The architecture of deniability -- compartmentalization, cutouts, verbal-only orders, the deliberate absence of documentation -- is itself a story element. The operator who is burned by their own government is not a cliché: it is a structural reality of how these operations are designed.

TECHNOLOGY IS NOT MAGIC

Satellite phones can be located. Encrypted communications can be compromised at the endpoint. Facial recognition requires a database match. Drones have limited loiter time and weather constraints. Every technology available to your protagonist is also available to your antagonist, and every technology has failure modes that fiction routinely ignores.

"The most dangerous assumption a writer can make is that the people doing this work are exceptional. Some are. Most are professionals doing a job under difficult conditions with imperfect information and inadequate resources. That is where the story actually lives."

-- Jonathan Baxter (The Brit), The Armory

SECTION 06

Explosives, Poisons, and Unconventional Weapons

The toolkit of the thriller villain -- and occasionally the thriller hero -- extends well beyond firearms. These weapons appear frequently in fiction and are almost always misrepresented in ways that undermine the story's credibility.

EXPLOSIVES -- THE BASICS FICTION MISSES

-> Blast radius is not uniform.

An explosion does not produce a perfect sphere of destruction. Shrapnel, building materials, and the geometry of the space create highly irregular damage patterns. A character behind a concrete wall twenty meters from a moderate explosion may be uninjured. A character in the open at the same distance may be killed by fragment.

-> The pressure wave is the primary killer.

In enclosed spaces, the overpressure from an explosion kills before the heat or shrapnel. Lungs, eardrums, and the GI tract are particularly vulnerable. A character who survives a close indoor explosion without hearing damage and internal injuries is not lucky -- they are fictional.

-> IEDs are built from available materials.

Improvised explosive devices reflect the geography and supply chain of the conflict. An IED in Afghanistan looks and functions differently from one in Northern Ireland or Beirut. The detonation mechanism, the container, the triggering method -- all are contextually specific.

POISONS AND CHEMICAL AGENTS -- FOR FICTION PURPOSES

Poisons in fiction serve a specific narrative function: the death that looks like something else. The most dramatically useful poisons share certain characteristics -- they are difficult to detect, they produce symptoms consistent with natural causes, and they have a window of effectiveness that creates story pressure.

-> Onset time is your story clock.

Different agents have radically different onset windows -- from seconds to days. The onset time determines when your killer must act, when your detective has time to intervene, and what your victim experiences. Use The Armory's toxicology context for specific agent timelines.

-> Detection windows determine your forensics.

Some agents degrade rapidly in the body. Others leave traces for weeks. The detection window determines whether the death can be proved as homicide after the fact -- and therefore whether your mystery can be solved.

-> Delivery method constrains your plot.

Ingestion, injection, inhalation, and skin contact all require different levels of access, preparation, and opportunity. The delivery method is not a minor detail -- it determines whether your killer could plausibly have been in position.

SECTION 07

Common Mistakes Action Writers Make

These are the errors that appear in editorial rejection letters, one-star reviews from veterans, and the margins of manuscripts returned by sensitivity readers with military or law enforcement backgrounds. They are all fixable.

THE HERO WHO NEVER MISSES

The error: Accurate shooting under stress is a perishable skill that degrades rapidly without regular training. Even trained operators miss under fire. The hit rate for law enforcement in actual gunfights is approximately 20-30%. A protagonist who shoots with surgical precision in every engagement, under any conditions, reads as a video game character, not a human being.

The fix: Let your protagonist miss. Let them waste rounds. Let the skill be variable based on conditions -- distance, stress, lighting, physical state.

KNIVES AS QUICK CLEAN KILLS

The error: Knife wounds in fiction kill instantly and silently. In reality, knife wounds are often not immediately incapacitating, are rarely silent (the victim's response is involuntary), and require specific anatomical targeting to be quickly lethal. A character killed silently with a knife by a non-expert is a fantasy.

The fix: Research the specific type of knife attack your scene requires. A trained operative targeting the subclavian artery is different from a desperate struggle with a kitchen knife. Both are dramatic. Neither is clean.

MILITARY RANK AND PROTOCOL ERRORS

The error: Characters address officers incorrectly, use the wrong branch's terminology, or behave in ways that violate basic military protocol. These errors are immediately visible to any veteran reader and signal that the writer did not consult anyone with actual military experience.

The fix: Use The Armory for branch-specific protocol. Address officers by rank, not "sir" alone. Know the difference between Army, Navy, Marines, and Special Forces culture -- they are not interchangeable.

THE INVINCIBLE PROTAGONIST

The error: Physical damage accumulates. A character who is punched, kicked, shot at, thrown from a vehicle, and engages in hand-to-hand combat across three consecutive days should be showing significant physical degradation. Ignoring cumulative physical damage is one of the most common action fiction failures.

The fix: Track your protagonist's physical state across the timeline of your story. Let the damage be present and affect their performance. Limitation creates drama.

SECTION 08

Writing Violence With Purpose

Violence in fiction is not decoration. It is not proof that your story is serious. It is a narrative tool -- and like all tools, its value depends entirely on how it is used.

THE PURPOSE TEST

Before writing any act of violence, apply the purpose test: what does this scene do that cannot be done another way? Violence in effective thrillers serves one or more of the following functions:

- > **Reveals character.** How a person commits, endures, or responds to violence tells the reader who they are at the level below their social performance.
- > **Changes the situation irreversibly.** After real violence, the world of the story is different. Someone is dead. A relationship is destroyed. A line has been crossed that cannot be uncrossed.
- > **Establishes stakes.** Violence that has consequences makes subsequent threat credible. Violence without consequences makes the story feel safe -- which is the opposite of thriller.
- > **Creates cost.** The protagonist who uses violence and pays no price for it is not interesting. The cost can be physical, psychological, relational, or moral -- but it must exist.

THE PACING OF VIOLENCE

Action sequences fail most often at the sentence level. The prose rhythm must match the speed of the action. Short sentences. Fragments, even. No subordinate clauses mid-firefight. The reader's eye should move as fast as the scene.

Conversely, the moment after violence -- the stillness, the assessment, the first full breath -- is often best served by longer, slower sentences that let the reader exhale with the character.

WHAT THE BRIT WILL AND WON'T TELL YOU

The Armory is a research tool for fiction writers. The Brit will tell you what a weapon sounds like, how it functions, what it does to a human body, and how a trained operator would use it in a specific scenario. He will not provide technical instructions for building weapons, synthesizing agents, or constructing devices. That distinction is not a limitation -- it is the difference between a tool for storytellers and something else entirely.

"I have spent a considerable portion of my professional life in situations that most people read about in novels. I am happy to help you write those situations accurately. I find inaccuracy professionally offensive."

-- Jonathan Baxter (The Brit), The Armory

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